

Final Round: Lisbon HQ HR Interview

The business already said yes. This round is yours to lose — be consistent, warm, and low-risk.

1 · What this round actually is

- The Head of Corporate Finance approved you on substance. **HR's job is to confirm, not re-test.** They screen for risk, fit and alignment — then close the admin (package, notice, start date).
- Expect **100% English**, most likely a **video call** from Lisbon, typically 30–45 minutes, softer pace than the business round.
- Winning behaviour: **likeable and safe**, not dazzling. The research bomb already landed in round one — with HR, deploy deep analysis **only if asked**.

2 · The five things HR is screening for

Screen	What it looks like	Your counter
1. Retention risk	The RM→Analyst move is a flag. They'll probe it in disguises: "are you sure?", "what if the pay disappoints?", "where in 5 years?"	Same calm answer every time: platform decision, eyes open, choosing to build (§3 below)
2. Consistency	They have notes from round one. Contradictions on motivation, salary, timeline or deal claims are red flags	Tell the same story — same numbers, same reasons, same tone
3. Compensation alignment	Your ask (MOP 650k take-home, +20%) is already in writing. Their fear: it's above the Analyst band — or you'll resent a lower offer and leave	Repeat the same numbers, defend the logic ("not a fresh graduate"), flex on structure not credibility (§3 Q4)
4. Culture & cross-border fit	European HQ, global footprint. Can you work with Lisbon, across time zones, in English?	Warmth, small talk, the Macau-Portugal connection (§5), group-level knowledge (§3)
5. Clean background	Banks verify everything: dates, degree, claims, restrictions from BOC	Only verifiable claims; honest answer on confidentiality / notice (§3)

3 · Likely questions — model answers

Q1. Walk me through your career and why this move. (90-second HR version — less technical than round one)

SAY THIS

"I've been at Bank of China, Macau for just over five years. The first two years, I was a product manager in digital finance. The last three years, I've been a Relationship Manager in corporate banking. I manage about 8 billion HKD in loans and 7 billion in deposits, and I've worked on more than 2 billion US dollars of deals.

I'm moving because Haitong offers something my current bank can't. It's an EU-regulated bank, owned by China's largest securities group, and it's just starting to build its corporate banking business in Macau. I want to help build that — and grow with it."

Q2. You're moving from RM to Analyst — are you sure? What if it disappoints? (THE retention probe — expect it more than once, in different clothes)

SAY THIS

"That's a fair question, and I didn't take this decision lightly. Three things give me confidence.

First, this move takes me toward the work I want — structured finance and capital markets. My current job can't give me that.

Second, I did my homework. I know exactly what stage the branch is at, so I'm coming in with realistic expectations — no surprises.

Third, the title matters less to me than the direction. An Analyst on a growing platform gets to build something. A comfortable RM on a mature platform mostly keeps things running. I'd rather build."

Q3. The branch had a difficult 2025 — doesn't that worry you? (only if THEY raise it)

SAY THIS

"I know — I read the branch's financial reports before my first interview. 2025 was tough because the fee income depends on mainland companies issuing bonds offshore, and that market slowed down.

But honestly, that's part of why this role makes sense. The bank is building corporate banking for exactly this reason: to add steady, recurring income next to the investment banking business. I'd rather join a platform at the start of that build than after it's finished."

Q4. Salary — your numbers are already on the table. Defend them, stay flexible on structure.

Your written position (email to Elsa Sousa, 10 July): current 12-month take-home ~**MOP 550,000**; asking ~**MOP 650,000** take-home (+20%). The interview answer must **match this exactly** — changing your numbers now would look inconsistent. Your job in the call: explain the logic calmly, and show flexibility on **structure**, not on credibility.

SAY THIS (when salary comes up)

"As I shared in my email, my take-home income over the past twelve months was about MOP 550,000. For this role, I'm looking for take-home of around 650,000 a year — about 20% above my current level.

Let me explain the logic. I know this is an Analyst role — but I'm not a fresh graduate. I bring five years of directly relevant experience, a client network in Macau, and I can contribute from day one. The 20% reflects that difference.

That said, I'm flexible on how the package is structured — base, bonus, and allowances are all open. What matters most to me is the platform and a fair total number."

IF THEY SAY IT'S ABOVE THE BAND

"I understand every role has a budget. May I ask what the band allows?

If the base is fixed, I'm open to looking at the total package — for example a performance bonus, or an earlier salary review after probation. I'm confident in what I'll deliver, so a performance-linked path works for me."

IF THEY ASK FOR THE MONTHLY BREAKDOWN

"Of course. My current package is a monthly base of [X], plus [allowances / annual bonus]. After tax, that came to about 550,000 over the last twelve months. I quoted take-home because it's the cleanest number to compare — but I'm happy to walk through the gross structure."

Discipline: (1) HR asked for **monthly basic + allowances** and you answered in **annual net** — have the monthly gross breakdown ready before the call, and make sure it matches your payslips: they said they may verify with documents. (2) Decide your true floor privately before the call (never say it). If they push below 650k, trade — earlier review, bonus, sign-on — instead of just dropping the number. (3) Never sound like the 20% is the reason you're moving; the platform is the reason, the 20% is fairness.

Q5. Notice period and start date?

SAY THIS

"My contract requires [X days / one month] notice. I can start on [date]. And I'll do a clean, professional handover — that's what I'd want from someone leaving my own team."

Q6. Are you bound by any restrictions from your current employer?

SAY THIS

"I have standard confidentiality duties, and I take them seriously. I won't bring any client data or internal documents with me. As far as I know, there's no non-compete that stops me from taking this role. What I bring is my skills, my training, and my knowledge of the market."

Q7. Tell me about a conflict with a colleague and how you handled it. (classic HR behavioral — adapt to a real case)

SAY THIS

"On one syndicated loan, a senior colleague wanted me to soften the risk section of my credit report so the approval would go faster. I had flagged that too much of the client's revenue came from one single buyer.

I didn't argue with him in the meeting. Afterwards, I prepared a one-page analysis showing how similar cases had gone wrong before. Then I offered a middle path: keep the risk flag, but add protections — a covenant and closer monitoring — so the deal could still move forward.

He agreed. The credit committee approved it with those protections, and the deal closed. What I learned is that if you disagree with data and respect, you usually end up with a better deal and a better relationship."

Q8. Tell me about a mistake you made. (pick a real, small, fixed one — never claim perfection, never pick a catastrophe)

SAY THIS

"Early in my product manager days, I published a monthly report with a data error. I had trusted the raw data without checking it myself, and a colleague caught the mistake.

I fixed it the same day and apologised directly. Then I built a simple checklist, and it became the standard for our whole team. We never had that problem again.

The lesson: moving fast without checking always costs more in the end. That's exactly the mindset credit work needs."

Q9. What do you know about Haitong Bank? (the GROUP version — a Lisbon HR manager will notice you know the European side)

SAY THIS

"Haitong Bank is an EU-regulated investment bank, headquartered in Lisbon. It started as the investment banking arm of Banco Espírito Santo, and Haitong acquired it in 2015. It has offices in Portugal, Spain, the UK, Poland, Brazil, and Macau. Today it's part of Guotai Haitong — China's largest securities group.

What makes it special is the bridge: a European licence and European standards, connected to Chinese deal flow. The Macau branch is the Asia-Pacific gateway of that bridge — and that's the part I want to help build."

4 · Questions to ask HR (different from business questions)

- "What does onboarding look like for Macau hires — and how is the probation period structured?"

- "How do Macau colleagues typically collaborate with the Lisbon teams — are there training programmes or visit opportunities with headquarters?" (signals long-term commitment)
- "What are the next steps and timeline from here?"

5 · Rapport: the Macau-Portugal card

- You are a Macau native talking to Lisbon. The **400-year Macau-Portugal connection** is the most natural rapport builder available: the architecture, the food, the street names, bilingual signage. One warm sentence in small talk ("working for a Lisbon-headquartered bank feels natural for someone from Macau — the connection is everywhere in my city") lands beautifully. Genuine, not flattery.
- European HR style: a little small talk first, softer pace, politeness. Mirror it. Smile. Don't rush to prove things.

6 · Video call logistics (if remote from Lisbon)

- [] Time zone: Lisbon is **7 hours behind** Macau in summer (10:00 Lisbon = 17:00 Macau) — double-check the invite
- [] Test camera/mic/link the day before · join 3-5 min early · quiet room, clean background, camera at eye level
- [] Full business dress even on video · phone silent · water ready
- [] Have the cram card and your CV printed beside you — glanceable, not readable-from

7 · Consistency checklist (match round one exactly)

- [] Same motivation story (platform, not title)
- [] Same salary numbers as your 10 July email: current take-home ~MOP 550k, asking ~650k (+20%) — never a different figure
- [] Monthly gross breakdown (base + allowances + bonus) prepared and matching your payslips — they said they may verify documents
- [] Same notice period and start date
- [] Same deal facts if Dali comes up (60-second non-technical version: "led the financing analysis for the take-private of a HK-listed food group — about HK\$7.6 billion — the deal I'm proudest of")
- [] Everything you claim must survive a background check

8 · After the call

- Send a short thank-you email the same day: 3-4 sentences, reaffirm enthusiasm, no new arguments.
- If they gave a timeline, wait it out + 2 business days before following up.

Mindset: the hard gate is behind you. HR needs to feel three things when the call ends: **he's staying, he's easy to work with, he'll represent us well.** Calm, warm, consistent.